

 Ask Anything Quick Summary

ice hockey

sport

 Stanley I. Fischler • All  Britannica Editors  Apr. 7, 2026

• [History](#)

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Ask Anything Quick Summary

 Table of Contents

Top Questions

- What is ice hockey? 
- Where is ice hockey most popular? 
- Is ice hockey an Olympic sport? 
- Where did ice hockey originate? 
-  Show more

News • [Avalanche clinch top spot in Western Conference and shift focus to bigger goals](#) • Apr. 7, 2026, 11:43 PM ET (AP) ...[\(Show more\)](#)

ice hockey, [game](#) between two teams, each usually having six players, who wear skates and compete on an [ice](#) rink. The object is to [propel](#) a vulcanized rubber disk, the [puck](#), past a goal line and into a [net](#) guarded by a goaltender, or goalie. With its speed and its frequent physical contact, ice hockey has become one of the most popular of international [sports](#). The game is an [Olympic](#) sport, and worldwide there are more than a million registered players performing regularly in leagues. It is perhaps [Canada](#)'s most popular game.



2018 Stanley Cup finals Goalie Marc-André Fleury of the Vegas Golden Knights blocking a shot by Jakub Vrána of the...[\(more\)](#)

History



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Origins

Until the mid-1980s it was generally accepted that ice hockey derived from [English field hockey](#) and the [Native American](#) game of [lacrosse](#) and was spread throughout Canada by [British](#) soldiers in the mid-1800s. Research then turned up evidence of a hockeylike game, played in the early 1800s in [Nova Scotia](#) by the [First Nations](#) tribe originally settled in what is now eastern Canada and the northeastern [United States](#)), which appeared to have been heavily influenced by the [Irish](#) game of [hurling](#); it included the use of a “hurley” (stick) and a square wooden block instead of a [ball](#). It was probably fundamentally this game that spread throughout Canada via [Scottish](#) and Irish immigrants and the [British army](#).

The players adopted elements of field hockey, such as the “bully” (later the face-off) and “shinning” (hitting one’s opponent on the shins with the stick or playing with the stick on one “shin” or side); this evolved into an informal ice game later known as [shinny](#) or shinty. The name *hockey*—as the organized game came to be known—has been [attributed](#) to the French word *hoquet* (shepherd’s stick). The term *rink*, referring to the designated area of play, was originally used in the game of [curling](#) in 18th-century Scotland. Early hockey games allowed as many as 30 players a side on the ice, and the goals were two stones, each frozen into one end of the ice. The first use of a puck instead of a ball was recorded at Kingston Harbour, Ontario, Canada, in 1860.



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Ice Hockey at the Winter Olympics: A Timeline



Milano Cortina 2026 Olympic Winter Games



Miracle on Ice

Early organization

The first recorded public indoor ice hockey game, with rules largely borrowed from field hockey, took place in [Montreal](#)’s Victoria Skating Rink in 1875 between two teams of [McGill University](#) students. Unfortunately, the reputation for violence that the game would later develop was presaged in this early [encounter](#), where, as *The Daily British Whig* of [Kingston, Ontario](#), reported, “Shins and heads were battered, benches smashed and the lady spectators fled in confusion.” The first organized team, the McGill University Hockey Club, formed in 1877, codified their game’s rules and limited the number of players on a side to nine.

By the late 1800s ice hockey competed with lacrosse as Canada’s most popular sport. The first national hockey organization, the Amateur Hockey Association (AHA) of Canada (which limited players to seven a side), was formed in Montreal in 1885, and the first league was formed in Kingston during the same year, with four teams: the Kingston Hockey Club, [Queen’s University](#), the Kingston Athletics, and the Royal Military College. Queen’s University score 1 – 0 in the first championship game.



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Great Moments in Sports Quiz

By the opening of the 20th century, sticks were being manufactured, shin pads were worn, the goaltender began to wear a chest protector (borrowed from baseball), and arenas (still with natural ice and no heat for spectators) were being constructed throughout eastern Canada. In 1893



national attention was focused on the game when the Canadian governor-general, [Frederick Arthur, Lord Stanley of Preston](#), donated a cup to be given annually to the top Canadian team. The three-foot-high silver cup became known as the [Stanley Cup](#) and was first awarded in 1892–93. (The first winner was the Montreal Amateur Athletic Association team, which also captured the Stanley Cup the following season by winning the initial challenge series to determine the Cup holder, which was the Cup-awarding format that Lord Stanley originally intended.) Since 1926 the cup has gone to the winner of the [National Hockey League](#) playoffs.



The Stanley Cup

In 1899 the Canadian Amateur Hockey League was formed. All hockey in Canada at the time was “amateur,” it being “ungentlemanly” to admit to being paid for athletic services. Thus, the first acknowledged professional hockey team in the world was formed in the United States, in 1903, in Houghton, Michigan. The team, the Portage Lakers, was owned by a dentist named J.L. Gibson, who imported Canadian players. In 1904 Gibson formed the first acknowledged professional league, the International Pro Hockey League. Canada accepted professional hockey in 1908 when the Ontario Professional Hockey League was formed. By that time Canada had become the center of world hockey.

League rivalries

The National Hockey Association (NHA), the forerunner of the National Hockey League (NHL), was organized in 1910 and became the strongest hockey association in [North](#)

[America](#). Rising interest in the game created problems, however, for there were few artificial-ice rinks. In 1911 the [Pacific Coast Hockey Association](#) (PCHA) was formed by Joseph Patrick and his sons, who built two enclosed artificial-ice arenas, beginning a boom in the construction of artificial-ice rinks.

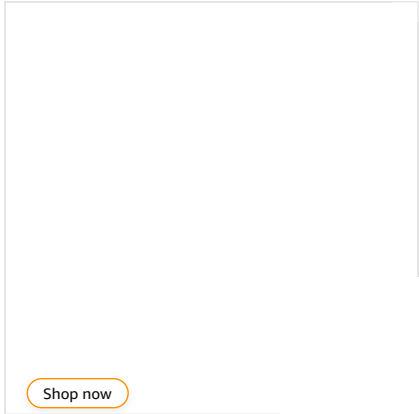


The PCHA became involved in the war with the NHA. Although the PCHA ultimately emerged as the stronger league, it was the PCHA that introduced many of the changes that improved the game. The only radical rule change adopted by the NHA was to reduce the number of players on a side to six, and that move was made to save money. The western league retained seven-man hockey, but it allowed the goalie to leap or [dive](#) to stop the puck. Under the previous rules, a goalie had to remain stationary when making a save. The western league also changed the offside rule. Under the old rules, a player was deemed offside if found to be ahead of the puck carrier when receiving a pass. The PCHA divided the ice into three zones by painting two blue lines across the surface and allowed forward passing in the center zone between the blue lines. This opened up the game and made it more exciting. Another [innovation](#) in the western league was the idea of the assist. Previously, only the goal scorer had been credited with a point. In the PCHA the player or players who set up a goal were credited with an assist. The first numbered uniforms also appeared in their league.

Related to Ice Hockey:
:: Jaroslav Drobny • Lester B. Patrick • Herb Brooks • Stan Mikita • Maurice Richard

Related Topics: [wrist shot](#) • [Triple Gold Club](#) • [puck](#) • [backhander](#) • [face-off](#)

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National Hockey League

Like some of its predecessors, the NHA had its dissenters. In a move to eject one of the league members, the NHA decided to disband and form a new league. The result was the creation in 1917 of the [National Hockey League](#) (NHL), which became the world's foremost professional hockey league. In 1924 the first U.S. team, the [Boston Bruins](#), joined the NHL. In 1925 the [New York Americans](#) and [Pittsburgh Pirates](#) were admitted, followed in 1926 by the [New York Rangers](#), the [Chicago Blackhawks](#), and the [Detroit Cougars](#) (later called the Red Wings). To stock the new teams, the NHL bought out the Patricks' league in 1926 for \$250,000. Among the players who shifted to [Boston](#) was [Eddie Shore](#), known as a "rushing" defenseman, whose style helped change the game. He was one of the sport's most ferocious and, many experts say, most skilled players, a forerunner of such future NHL players as [Gordie Howe](#), who played mostly for the Detroit Red Wings. The Pittsburgh Pirates and the New York Americans eventually dropped out of the league, and, until the expansion of 1967, the NHL was composed of only six teams: the Rangers, the Bruins, the Blackhawks, the Red Wings, the [Toronto Maple Leafs](#), and the [Montreal Canadiens](#).

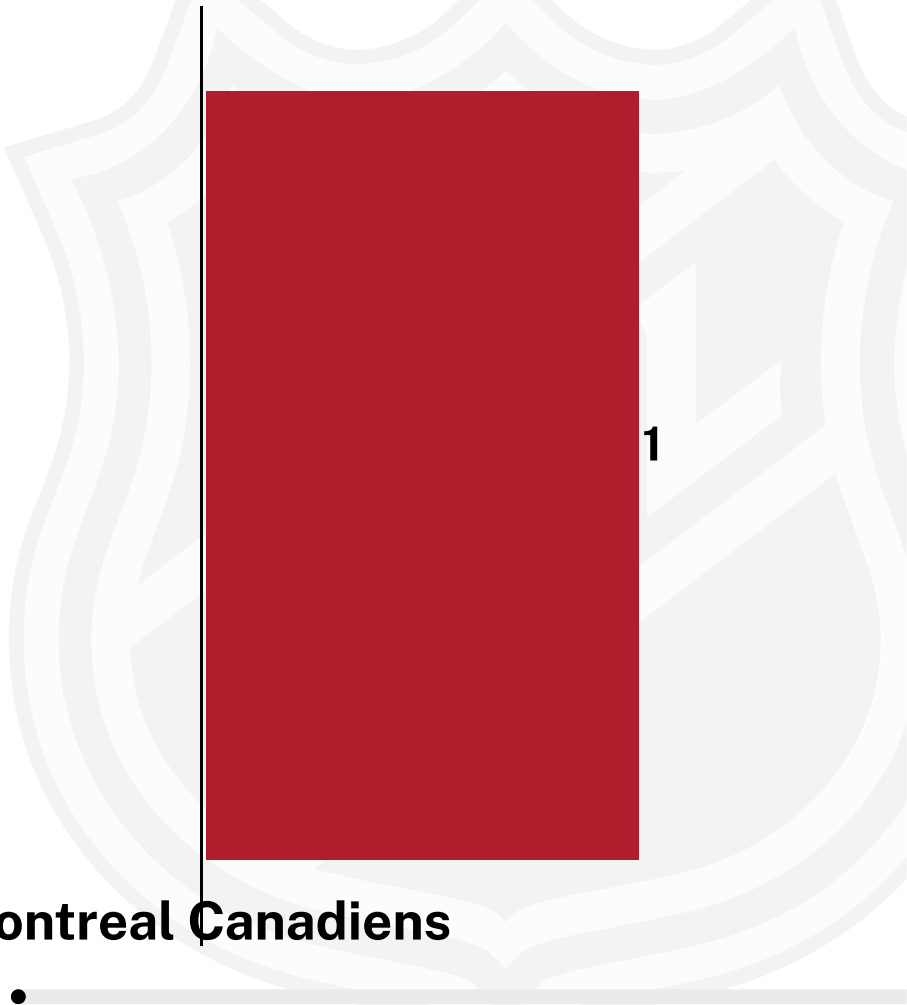


"Mr. Hockey" Gordie Howe, 1969.

In 1967 the NHL doubled in size to 12 teams. A new 12-team league, the [World Hockey Association](#) (WHA), was formed in 1972, and the ensuing rivalry caused an escalation in players' salaries. In 1979 the NHL, which had grown to 17 teams, merged with the WHA to become a 21-team league. By 2017, 31 teams played in the NHL. A new franchise was added in 2021 to increase the number of participating teams to 32.

A major disruption occurred in 2004 when owners locked out players, insisting that they accept a salary cap that would slow the rapid growth of payroll costs. The players rejected the owners' demands, and the entire 2004–05 season was canceled. The league resumed play in 2005–06 after the owners ultimately [prevailed](#), and the NHL became the last of the major North American team-sport leagues to institute a salary cap.

NUMBER OF STANLEY CUP WINS BY CURRENT NHL



Montreal Canadiens



Credit: © NHL

FOOTNOTE

SEE DATA AS TABLE

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The regular season consists of 82 games and determines the 16 teams that will qualify for the playoffs. The playoff winner is awarded the [Stanley Cup](#). NHL individual awards are the [Vezina Trophy](#), for the goalie voted best at this position by NHL managers; the William M. Jennings Trophy, for the goalie or goalies with the team permitting the fewest goals; the Calder Memorial Trophy, for the rookie of the year; the [Hart Memorial Trophy](#), for the most valuable player; the James Norris Memorial Trophy, for the outstanding defenseman; the [Art Ross Trophy](#), for the top point scorer; the Lady Byng Memorial Trophy, for the player best [combining](#) clean play with a high degree of skill; the Conn Smythe Trophy, for the playoffs' outstanding performer; the Frank J. Selke Trophy, for the best defensive forward; the Jack Adams Award, for the coach of the year; the Bill Masterton Memorial Trophy, for the player who best exemplifies sportsmanship, perseverance, and dedication to hockey; and the Lester Patrick Trophy, for outstanding service to U.S. hockey.

International ice hockey

For much of the 20th century, amateur athletes dominated international competition. League competition among amateurs in England began in 1903. The International Ice Hockey Federation (IIHF) was formed in [Europe](#). Its original members were [Canada](#), [Switzerland](#), [France](#), and [Belgium](#). The first European championship was held at Avants, Switzerland, in 1910, with Great Britain the winner. From that time the federation broadened its membership, taking applicants from the world over. [Canada](#) captured the first [Olympic Games](#) title in 1920 and, concurrently, the first IIHF world championship. Canada, which also won at the first Olympic Winter Games in 1924, dominated international competition until the emergence of the Soviet team in the early 1960s. The Soviets continued to be the most powerful team in international hockey until the 1990s and the [dissolution of the Soviet Union](#).



James Craig in action 1980 U.S. Olympic men's hockey team goalie James Craig making a save during the "Miracle on Ice" game. [\(more\)](#)

Ice Hockey at the Winter Olympics: A Timeline



This timeline charts key [milestones](#) in the history of [ice](#) hockey at the Winter Olympics.

In 1995 an agreement between the NHL, the NHL Players' Association, and the IIHF ended amateur domination of international play as professional athletes were allowed to compete at the [Olympics](#) and World Cup championships. Although the decision had little effect on the world [tournament](#), the Winter Games competition underwent numerous changes. Given the high visibility of professional players and their skills, selection to the Canadian, U.S., Russian, Finnish, Swedish, and Czech Olympic teams was no longer based on tryouts but rather on the decisions of hockey personnel from each country's national hockey governing body. The six "dream teams" were automatically placed in the final round of eight; the two remaining slots were filled by the winners of a qualifying round. The NHL suspended play for a period of 16 days in 1998 so professional players could make their Olympic debut in [Nagano, Japan](#), and it continued to temporarily stop the season for Olympic play thereafter.

After the [Sochi 2014 Games](#), a dispute erupted between the NHL and the IOC over which organization should cover participation-related costs, such as travel, insurance, and accommodations for participating athletes. This dispute was [compounded](#) by multiple NHL franchises criticizing the midseason disruption to the league schedule and the risk of injury to its players during the Olympics. The NHL ultimately chose not to participate in the [2018 Winter Olympics](#) in Pyeongchang, [South Korea](#), after participating in five consecutive Winter Games. The disruption to the NHL regular season caused by the

aftermath of the [COVID-19](#) pandemic meant that NHL players also did not participate in the [2022 Beijing Games](#).

In 2024 NHL executives said they were planning the return of “best-on-best” hockey (a [colloquial](#) term used to describe international hockey and Olympic events that feature professional players) for the [2026 Winter Games](#). They announced that NHL players would again be eligible to participate in the 2026 and 2030 Olympics. In July 2025 the NHL, the NHL Players’ Association, and the IIHF signed a formal agreement to this effect at the IOC headquarters in Switzerland.



Men’s ice hockey Olympic gold med

Note: Russia’s totals include Soviet Union, Unified Team, and Olympic Athletes from Russia.

Source: International Ice Hockey Federation:
Olympic Winter Games.

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Women’s hockey

Though sometimes considered primarily a male sport, hockey has been played by women for more than 120 years. The first all-female game was in Barrie, Ontario, Canada, in 1892, and the first world championship was held in 1990. Recognizing the growing popularity of the sport, the [International Olympic Committee](#) added women’s ice hockey to its [1998 schedule at Nagano](#), where the sport made its first Winter Games appearance.

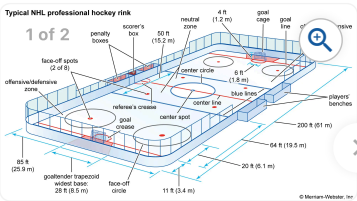


A number of women’s hockey leagues have been formed around the world. In [North America](#), the premier organization is the [Professional Women’s Hockey League](#) (established 2023).

Play of the game

Rink and equipment

[NHL](#) hockey is typically played on a standard-size rink shaped like a round-cornered rectangle that is 200 feet (61 meters) long and 85 feet (26 meters) wide. International rinks are usually 184–200 feet by 85–98 feet, and U.S. college rinks are typically 200 feet by 100 feet. The goal cage is 4 feet (1.2 meters) high and 6 feet (1.8 meters) wide. Any shot that completely clears the goal line, a 2-inch- (5-cm-) wide stripe on the [ice](#) across the front of the cage, is a goal. In front of the goal is the [crease](#), a semicircular area that corresponds to a circle with a 6-foot radius, demarcated by a red line. When the goalie is in the crease, no attacking player may enter unless the puck is there as well; if the goalie is not in the crease, however, anyone may enter. The blue lines that divide the ice into three zones are 60 feet (18 meters) out from the goal line and are painted across the width of the ice. The area between the blue lines is called the neutral zone. This zone is bisected by the red center line.



Ice hockey rink A typical professional North American ice hockey rink. U.S. college rinks are sometimes wider [\(.more\)](#)

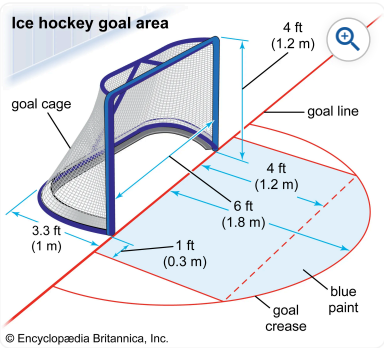
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Virtually all equipment—for children, [amateurs](#), or professionals—is the same. Made of vulcanized [rubber](#), the puck is 1 inch (2.5 cm) thick and 3 inches (7.6 cm) in diameter and weighs 5.5 to 6 ounces (156 to 170 grams). Hockey sticks, once made from wood, are now formed from a variety of materials. Rules are enforced limiting the size of the stick and the curvature of its blade. Forwards and defensemen wear the same type of



skates, but goaltenders have flatter blades because they need more balance and are stationary for longer periods. The shoes of goaltenders' skates are fitted with rubber protection for the toes. Players wear padding under their uniforms to protect legs, shoulders, and arms. Since 1979–80 all players entering the NHL must wear helmets; helmets and face masks are mandatory in [National Collegiate Athletic Association](#) (NCAA) and IIHF play. The goaltender wears a specially designed mask (often molded to the [contours](#) of the face).


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A goalie wears extra equipment above the uniform. Pads up to 11 inches (25.4 cm) wide serve as protection from the tips of the skates to above the knees. They also aid in blocking shots. On their free hand, goalies wear a glove similar to a first baseman's [baseball](#) mitt, with a wide webbing that enables them to catch the puck. The stick hand is encased in a glove with a wide backing that protects the arm. The goalie's stick has a wider shaft and blade than those of the other players. Fully dressed, goaltenders carry up to 40 pounds (18 kg) of equipment.

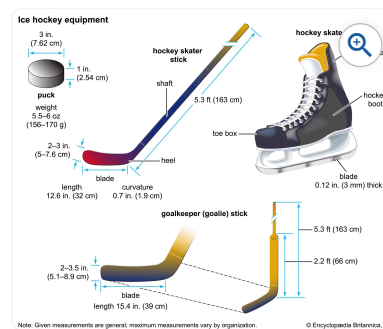
Rules and principles of play

The modern game on every level—amateur, [collegiate](#), international, and professional—has been influenced largely by the NHL.


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Crease An illustration of the goal area of an ice hockey rink, also known as the “crease.”



Ice hockey equipment The equipment shown is used by defensemen and forwards. Goaltenders use a skate with a flatter L..[\(more\)](#)

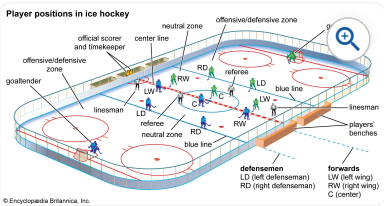
Checking—body contact to take an opponent out of play—is permitted anywhere on the ice. In most leagues, including the NHL, players may not make or take a pass that has traveled across the two blue lines; if this occurs, the play is ruled offside. A face-off, in which an official drops the puck between opposing players, follows the infraction. Face-offs are held at the point of the infraction. Players who precede the puck into the attacking zone also are ruled offside, and a face-off is held at a face-off spot near the attacking blue line. A face-off also begins each period and is used as well after a goal and after any stoppage of play.



Britannica Quiz

Great Moments in Sports Quiz

Goalies rarely leave their respective goal areas. The usual alignments of the other five players are three forwards—the center, a left wing, and a right wing—and two defensemen—a left defenseman and a right defenseman.



Player positions in ice hockey A typical modern lineup in the game consist of a goaltender, two defensemen, and thre...(more)

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There are no limits on how often or how long a player may handle the puck, provided the

generally not subject to these restrictions.

The game is divided into three periods of 20 minutes playing time each, with a 15-minute intermission between periods. Hockey games may end in a tie unless the rules stipulate an overtime period to serve as a tiebreaker. In the case of a tie in college hockey, one 10-minute sudden-death overtime period is played in regular season play. NHL teams play a five-minute sudden-death overtime period, followed by a shoot-out if the game remains tied. During the playoffs, college hockey has 10-minute overtime periods until there is a winner, while the NHL has the same system with 20-minute periods. There is generally no overtime period in international hockey; however, Olympic competition since 1994 has had a 10-minute sudden-death period, followed by a shoot-out if needed.

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In organized ice hockey a victory is worth two points in the standings. A tie is worth one point, and the NHL, which has no ties, awards a point to a team that loses in overtime. A goal counts as a point for the team, but individual points may be awarded to as many as three players for one goal. One point goes to the player who scored the goal, and a point is awarded for an assist to each of the last two of the scorer's teammates who touched the puck, providing that the opposition did not handle the puck in the [interim](#).



What Do You Think?

- [Should Fighting Be Allowed in Hockey?](#)

Explore the ProCon debate.

Ice hockey is the only major sport in which [substitutions](#) are permitted while the game is in play. The game is so fast and so demanding that forwards generally skate only 90 seconds at a time. Defensemen usually stay on the ice for a slightly longer period of time.

Because of the speed and contact, there are many infractions, not all of them having to do with “hitting” penalties. Play is stopped for an offside and for the infraction called icing, which occurs when a team shoots the puck out of its zone past the other team’s goal line. Icing is not called against a team when it is shorthanded; if the teams are evenhanded or if the offending team has more players than the opposing team, the puck is returned to the defensive zone of the team that iced it for the face-off. No player, however, may [delay](#) the game by intentionally [shooting](#) the puck out of the rink or by shifting the goalposts.



Minor penalties are most commonly assessed for excessive use of the body or equipment to impede the opposition. For a minor infraction the offending player must remain in the penalty box at the side of the rink for two minutes while the team plays shorthanded. This man-advantage situation is called a power play. If the opponents score at any time during the penalty period, the penalized player may return to the ice. Penalties incurred by the goalie are served by a teammate. A major penalty for violent play results in the loss of a player for five minutes or for the remainder of the game. If major penalties are incurred simultaneously by both teams, [substitutions](#) are made and there is no shorthanded play. A game misconduct penalty for abusing an official results in the loss of a player for 10 minutes; however, a substitution is allowed, and the team does not play shorthanded.

There are three common types of shots in hockey: the slap shot, the wrist shot, and the backhand. The slap shot has been timed at more than 100 miles an hour (160 km an hour). The slap shot differs from the wrist shot in that the player brings the stick back until it is nearly perpendicular with the ice and then brings the stick down in an arc, swatting the puck and following through. It is not as accurate as the wrist shot, in which the player puts the stick on the ice near the puck and without a [windup](#) snaps the wrist to fire off a shot. The backhand is taken when the puck goes to the other side of the stick from which the player normally shoots. A right-handed shooter, for example, takes the backhand from the left side. It is taken when there is not enough time to shift the puck to a normal shooting position. The backhand generally is not as hard or as accurate as the wrist shot, but it has the advantage of being taken quickly.